REVISITING AGNIPATH



The Agnipath scheme, introduced by the Indian government on June 14, 2022, promised a radical overhaul of the country's well-established military recruitment process. Under it, youths between the ages of 17.5 and 21 years, christened Agniveers, would be inducted for a four-year tenure, and 25 per cent of these recruits (all below officer rank) would be retained for regular service based on merit and organisational requirements. The rest would be discharged with a severance package and assistance for future employment.

Agnipath was aimed at modernising the armed forces—seeking to lower the age profile, enhance physical fitness and build a technically adept military capable of addressing future challenges. It was also thought that Agniveers would enter the civilian workforce with valuable skills imbibed over four years. Another crucial objective was to ease, through the Agnipath's shorter service duration, the burgeoning defence pension bill.

However, despite its well-publicised objectives, the scheme triggered widespread protests across India. With the armed forces being considered as a secure refuge guaranteeing pension, the main concern among potential recruits was about job security and future prospects of Agniveers after their four-year tenure. Critics also argued